

DATA 202 — Forum 1

Ch. 1 — "There's No Such Thing as a Raw Number"

Group members (all three names):

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

Week 3 — Exploring DataFrames

Stone's argument: before anything can be counted, someone has to decide what belongs in the same category — which means deciding which real differences to ignore. That decision is creative and value-laden, not objective. A pain scale from 1–10 flattens a patient's experience into a single digit; the U.S. Census's racial categories force multiracial identities into single boxes; whether cheerleading counts as a "varsity sport" under Title IX has no purely factual answer.

Discuss and write a response to each question below (~25 min).

1. Stone shows that categorizing always means ignoring some differences to treat things as alike. When you use `groupby()` on a column like `region` or `dynasty`, what real differences between rows are you choosing to ignore? Who would notice, and who wouldn't?

2. Every feature column in a dataset is itself a category someone defined. Pick a column from a dataset you've worked with this semester and describe the judgment call embedded in it — the moment someone decided what counts as a "value" for that column.

3. To count someone is to make them *visible* in a certain way — to a researcher, an institution, an algorithm. Being counted can bring resources and recognition, but that same visibility can expose someone to a “gaze” they never agreed to and can’t return. Psalm 139 describes being fully known by God (“you have searched me and known me... you discern my thoughts from afar”) — a seeing with no distance and no power grab in it. Where do you think that a dataset’s gaze fall short of that kind of knowing, and who bears the cost when it does?

4. Compare notes. After discussing with a classmate, write down one point where their answer differed from yours, or one idea of theirs you hadn’t considered — in their words, noting whose idea it was.